WORLD WAR I IN NORTHWEST EUROPE

The world's two most powerful and expensive navies spent most of World War I facing each other across the North Sea, too cautious to go out and do battle. Both sides went out on patrol and laid mines as close as they could to the enemy's coast, but neither was prepared to risk its fleet. Two cruiser squadrons clashed briefly at Dogger Bank in 1915, but it was not until May the following year that the two sides finally met at Jutland for the only large-scale fleet action of the war. What became clear at the battle was that the British fleet was still much more powerful than the German one. Realizing this, the Germans tried to win the war by means of a U-boat campaign against Allied and neutral shipping, aimed at starving Britain into submission, a plan in which they very nearly succeeded. After Jutland the German High Seas Fleet never again ventured out into the North Sea.

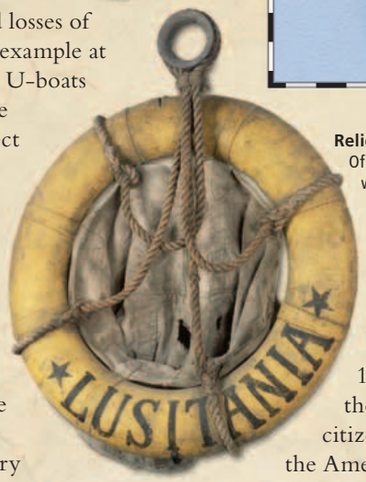
KEY

- Allied Powers
- Central Powers
- Neutral states
- Western Front 1916
- British naval base
- German naval base
- British port bombarded by Germans 1914–16
- British raid on German base 1918
- British mine barrage 1914–15
- British minefield
- German minefield
- British naval blockade
- British victory
- Inconclusive action



time would become irrelevant. Allied losses of warships to mines were grievous, for example at the Dardanelles in 1915, and German U-boats continued to be a threat even after the adoption of destroyer screens to protect battleships and cruisers.

It was when U-boats were deployed as commerce raiders, first in 1915 and then on a larger scale in 1917, that they threatened to change the course of the war. At the start of the war U-boat attacks on merchant shipping were conducted for the most part according to prize regulations, the traditional rules for cruisers attacking unarmed civilian shipping. In February 1915, however, Germany declared the waters around Britain a war zone and authorized U-boat captains to attack merchant vessels, including neutrals, without warning. The



Relic of the Lusitania
Of the 1,201 passengers drowned when the *Lusitania* was sunk by a torpedo, 128 were US citizens.

sinking of the liner *Lusitania* in May 1915 and the cross-Channel ferry *Sussex* in March 1916 both resulted in the deaths of many US citizens. So incensed were the Americans that the Germans were forced to call off the campaign. But, when the idea of a full-scale surface battle was abandoned after Jutland, Germany resumed unrestricted submarine warfare on February 1, 1917. The reluctance of the British to adopt a convoy system led to a period of unsustainable losses of merchant ships to U-boat attack. This continued up until May 1917, when the phasing in of convoys reversed the trend. But indiscriminate sinkings by U-boats brought America into the war against Germany, ensuring the eventual victory of the Allies.

Morale in the German High Seas Fleet suffered from its years of inactivity in port. When the German commanders planned a sortie to engage the Grand Fleet in a death-or-glory final battle in October 1918, the sailors mutinied. Interned at Scapa Flow, the German fleet was scuttled by its crews in protest against the Versailles peace treaty in June 1919.

U-boat in port
Launched in 1911, U-8 had only a short career. She was trapped in nets off Folkestone in the English Channel in March 1915 and sunk by the British destroyers *Gurkha* and *Maori*. All her crew were rescued.

